

Mengjun Chen

Rutgers University–New Brunswick

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Available for full-time employment: June 2027

Profile

Economics Ph.D. candidate with an M.S. in Statistics and experience in economic forecasting, machine learning, and statistical software development. Develops methods for economic measurement and forecast evaluation, with a focus on data revisions, training instability, and high-dimensional predictors.

Education

Rutgers University–New Brunswick

New Brunswick, NJ

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (expected June 2027)

Sept. 2021–Present

Advisor: Norman R. Swanson, Distinguished Professor of Economics

- Exchange Student, New York University

Sept. 2023–May 2024

National University of Singapore

Singapore

M.S. in Statistics

Aug. 2019–Jan. 2021

Nankai University

Tianjin, China

B.A. in Finance

Mar. 2014–Jul. 2016

Tianjin University

Tianjin, China

B.S. in Applied Chemistry

Sept. 2012–Jul. 2016

Technical Skills & Languages

Programming & Data: Python, R, SQL (MySQL), MATLAB

Econometrics & Machine Learning: Time-series econometrics, factor models, VARs, autoencoders, LSTMs, robust and clustered inference

Structural Modeling: Dynare (DSGE solution, calibration, and estimation)

Languages: Mandarin (native), English (fluent)

Research

Measuring Macroeconomic Uncertainty in Real Time: The Role of Data Revisions

Job Market Paper

- Built a matched real-time/pseudo-final evaluation framework that holds information coverage fixed to isolate how data revisions affect uncertainty measurement.
- Developed a theoretical framework separating revisions to measured outcomes from revisions to forecasting information, and a factor-based measure that trades broader uncertainty coverage for lower direct revision exposure.
- Evaluated alternative uncertainty measures using a common VAR design and real-time out-of-sample forecasts to assess their economic interpretation and predictive usefulness.

Randomized Forecasting Rules and Deployment Risk

Work in Progress

- Develops a framework for evaluating forecasts when repeated model training produces different predictions, distinguishing single-model deployment from averaging independent models.
- Estimates and compares prediction risk across ensemble sizes using repeated training runs, accounting for time dependence to inform model selection and deployment decisions.

Learning Forecastable Factors When Targets Are Scarce

Work in Progress

- Develops predictive factors for settings with limited or noisy target supervision by combining target prediction with prediction of future panel outcomes within historical training samples.
- Connects partial least squares and supervised autoencoders through a target-weighted learning framework, examining when auxiliary prediction tasks strengthen or weaken target forecasts.

The Inflation Content of Unemployment

Presented at the Chinese Economists Society North American Annual Conference, 2025

- Derives an unemployment measure for inflation analysis from a production-chain model with matching frictions and employed search, weighting labor-market conditions by their contribution to labor costs.
- Uses a conditional U.S. goods-sector calibration to examine how similar aggregate unemployment rates can mask different labor-cost pressures and implications for inflation.

Experience & Projects

Developer, avgEffect R Package

Completed Oct. 2025

- Developed the avgEffect R package for coefficient and average partial-effect estimation with heteroskedasticity-robust and one- and two-way clustered standard errors, supporting research by Ruonan Xu and Luther Yap published in the *Journal of Econometrics*.

Data Strategy Specialist Intern (Full-time), Baidu, Inc.

Mar.–Jun. 2021

- Built a SQL-based data analysis system and used Python and SQL to analyze and forecast business performance, producing analytical reports for business teams.

Lecturer, Rutgers University–New Brunswick

Summers 2024 and 2025

- Independently taught Intermediate Macroeconomic Analysis; received an overall student evaluation of 4.83/5.00 in Summer 2025.

Honors and Awards

- Hiroki Tsurumi and Peter J. Zangari Endowed Graduate Dissertation Fund in Economics, 2026.
- Sidney I. Simon Prize for Outstanding Graduate Student Teaching, 2025.
- Richard Lock Endowed Fund for Economics Award, 2025.
- Rie Ashizawa Memorial Award/Prize, Economics Ph.D. qualifying examinations, 2022.